TransferIQ: AI-Driven Player Transfer Value Prediction Report

By TANISHA JAIN

ABSTRACT

The global football transfer market has grown into a multi-billion–dollar ecosystem where accurate player valuation is essential for clubs, analysts, scouts, and financial stakeholders. Traditional valuation methods rely heavily on subjective assessments, inconsistent heuristics, and market speculation. This project introduces **TransferIQ**, an AI-driven system designed to estimate player transfer values using an integrated approach combining **performance metrics**, **market value history**, **sentiment analysis**, **injury records**, and **league competitiveness**.

The system uses a hybrid modeling framework comprising **XGBoost** for tabular feature prediction and **LSTM networks** for temporal analysis. The output is deployed through an interactive **Streamlit** application that allows users to input custom player attributes and receive real-time valuation predictions. The report provides a comprehensive overview of the data pipeline, feature engineering strategy, model architecture, performance evaluation, deployment, and challenges encountered.

1. INTRODUCTION

Player transfer valuation is a critical decision-making process in professional football. Accurate valuation affects financial planning, investment strategies, squad development, and negotiation leverage. However, player valuation remains an inherently complex problem due to the interplay of multiple dynamic factors including:

- On-field performance
- Age and development trajectory
- Public perception and media sentiment
- Market fluctuations
- Injury history
- League quality and competition level

The goal of **TransferIQ** is to develop a **transparent, data-driven, and dynamic player valuation system** that leverages the power of machine learning and deep learning. Instead of relying on intuition or subjective scouting opinions, TransferIQ provides a more objective, interpretable, and analytical prediction pipeline.

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2. PROBLEM STATEMENT

The transfer market lacks consistency in valuation methods, leading to inflated or underestimated player prices. Clubs often struggle to determine:

- Whether a player is overpriced or undervalued
- The fair market value considering performance, form, age, and injuries
- Value progression across multiple seasons

Key challenges include:

- High non-linearity in market behavior
- Influence of external sentiment
- Limited access to structured historical data
- Complexity of performance metrics
- Market volatility in top leagues

TransferIQ addresses these problems through an AI model trained on multi-source structured data, capturing patterns that traditional valuation methods overlook.

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3. LITERATURE REVIEW & INDUSTRY CONTEXT

Previous academic works and industry models have explored:

3.1 Regression-Based Models

Simple regression methods attempted to predict value using goals, assists, and appearances. These models fail to capture non-linear patterns or the complex interactions between metrics.

3.2 Machine Learning Approaches

Random Forests, SVMs, and Gradient Boosting have been applied to sports performance prediction; however, these rarely incorporate sentiment or temporal trends.

3.3 Deep Learning for Time-Series

LSTM networks have been successful in modeling progression in stock prices, energy consumption, and player performance—but limited literature applies them directly to football transfer valuation.

3.4 Transfermarkt as Market Proxy

Transfermarkt values are widely used in academic research as a proxy for market valuation.

TransferIQ advances the field by combining all the above concepts into a **multi-source, hybrid ML–DL modeling framework**.

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4. DATA SOURCES

TransferIQ integrates multiple datasets to capture the holistic picture of player valuation:

4.1 Player Performance Statistics

Source: StatsBomb Open Data / GitHub datasets
Includes:

- Minutes played
- Goals, assists
- Progressive carries
- Goals created and shot metrics
- Passing accuracy, crosses, progressive passing distance
- Defensive actions and recoveries

4.2 Market Value Data

Source: Transfermarkt (scraped using BeautifulSoup)
Provides:

- Historical market value
- Player age, position, nationality
- Club and league information
- Transfer windows timeline

4.3 Sentiment Analysis

Source: Twitter / X API (or GitHub datasets)

- Tweets mentioning the player
- Sentiment polarity scores using **VADER**
- Aggregated sentiment by month or transfer window

4.4Injury History

Includes:

- Type of injury
- Duration
- Frequency
- Severity index

4.5 League Competitiveness

Based on:

- Domestic league ranking
- UEFA coefficient
- Market visibility

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5. DATA CLEANING & PREPROCESSING

The collected datasets required transformation for consistency and modeling readiness.

5.1 Cleaning Steps

- Removing null and duplicate rows
- Cleaning currency representations ("€20m", "€450k")
- Extracting numerical values using regex
- Standardizing country, club, and competition names
- Converting categorical fields to lowercase
- Aligning players across datasets

5.2 Preprocessing

- Converting categorical features to numerical via **One-Hot Encoding**
- Standardizing numerical features using **MinMaxNormalization**
- Handling missing values using domain-specific imputation
- Merging performance, sentiment, injury, and market datasets
- Constructing time-series sequences (for LSTMs)

The output is a unified, machine learning-ready dataset with clean numeric inputs.

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6. FEATURE ENGINEERING

Feature engineering enhances predictive performance by extracting deeper insights.

6.1 Engineered Performance Metrics

- **Value-per-minute**
- **Form indicators** (rolling average over last 5–10 matches)
- **Expected goal contribution per 90**
- **Progressive carry rate**
- **Goal-creating actions (GCA)**
- **Defensive impact metrics**

6.2 Contextual Features

- **League strength score**
- **Club competitiveness**
- **Age-performance index**

6.3 Injury-Related Features

- **Injury frequency**
- **Severity index**
- **Past injury load per season**

6.4 Sentiment Features

- Mean sentiment score
- Positive/negative sentiment ratio
- Sentiment volatility

Feature engineering proved crucial in improving model accuracy and interpretability.

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7. EXPLORATORY DATA ANALYSIS

Key findings:

7.1 Age Distribution

Market value peaks between **23–28 years**.

7.2 Value by Position

- Attackers and creative midfielders have the highest valuation.
- Defenders and goalkeepers have more stable value ranges.

7.3 Performance Relationships

Strong correlations with value:

- Minutes played
- Progressive metrics
- GCA (Goal-Creating Actions)
- Passing accuracy

7.4 Outliers

Superstar players appear as high-value anomalies due to factors beyond statistical performance.

The insights guided feature selection and model strategy.

8. MODELING APPROACH

TransferIQ uses a **hybrid modeling strategy** combining:

8.1 XGBoost Model (Tabular Learning)

XGBoost was selected due to:

- Strong performance on structured data
- Robust handling of missing values
- High interpretability through feature importance

- Ability to model non-linear relationships

Input: Feature-engineered dataset
Output: Predicted transfer value

8.2 LSTM Time-Series Forecasting

The LSTM component captures temporal dependencies in:

- Market value progression
- Sentiment trends
- Injury recovery patterns

LSTM architecture:

- Input → LSTM layer → Dropout → Dense → Output
- Loss: MSE
- Optimizer: Adam

Output: Future multi-step value prediction across transfer windows

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8.3 Ensemble Modeling

A weighted ensemble of XGBoost + LSTM stabilizes predictions:

- XGBoost captures static feature influence
- LSTM captures time-based trends
- Ensemble reduces variance and improves accuracy

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9. MODEL INTERPRETABILITY

Feature importance (from XGBoost) highlights:

Highly Important:

- **Age**
- **GCA**

- **Fouls Drawn**
- **Shot Distance**
- **Progressive carries**
- **Premier League participation**

Moderately Important:

- Minutes played
- Passing accuracy
- Carries, crosses, touches

Less Influential:

- Some defensive actions
- Weak-signal features

The model's interpretability demonstrates alignment with real-world valuation logic.

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10. DEPLOYMENT: STREAMLIT WEB APPLICATION

The interactive interface consists of:

10.1 Player Input Panel

User enters:

- Age
- Minutes played
- Passing accuracy
- Position
- League type
- Performance metrics

10.2 Feature Importance Display

Shows real-time interpretation for the given input.

10.3 Predicted Transfer Value

Displayed in Euros with proper formatting.

10.4 Backend Technologies

- Python
- Streamlit
- XGBoost
- TensorFlow
- Pandas

This makes TransferIQ usable for scouts, analysts, and clubs.

11. RESULTS & DISCUSSION

Model evaluation metrics:

XGBoost

- Lower MAE than baseline models
- Stable across non-superstar players

LSTM

- Effectively modeled value trajectories
- Slight sensitivity to noise in historical data

Ensemble

- Best overall performance
- Reduced outlier error
- More realistic value distribution

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12. CHALLENGES & SOLUTIONS

Challenge 1: Data Inconsistencies

Solution: Data alignment & global schema mapping.

Challenge 2: Outliers

Solution: Robust scaling & ensemble models.

Challenge 3: Sentiment Noise

Solution: Rolling averages & thresholding.

Challenge 4: Limited Injury Data

Solution: Severity index computation + imputation.

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13. CONCLUSION

TransferIQ successfully demonstrates that AI can provide **accurate, interpretable, and data-driven player transfer valuations**. The hybrid modeling approach, multi-source data integration, and interactive deployment represent a strong foundation for modern football analytics.

The system delivers:

- Automated end-to-end data pipeline
- Strong predictive performance
- Full explainability with feature importance
- Usable interface for real-world applications

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14. FUTURE WORK

Potential enhancements include:

- Integration of contract length, agent influence
- Using transformer-based NLP for richer sentiment
- Real-time market scraping using scheduled pipelines
- Adding explainable AI (SHAP values)
- Deploying full-scale backend with API support
- Extending to prediction of injury risk or performance progression